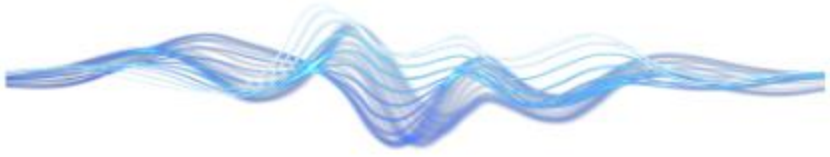
Ed AI Series

# How to Become an AI-Literate Teacher

A Step-by-Step Guide

Med Kharbach, PhD



www.educatorstechnology.com

Educators Technology

# Copyright © 2026 Med Kharbach, PhD

This work is licensed under a Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-ShareAlike 4.0 International License. You are free to share (copy and redistribute the material in any medium or format) and adapt (remix, transform, and build upon the material) under the following conditions: appropriate credit must be given, a link to the license must be provided, and any changes must be indicated. The material may not be used for commercial purposes. If you remix, transform, or build upon the material, you must distribute your contributions under the same license as the original.

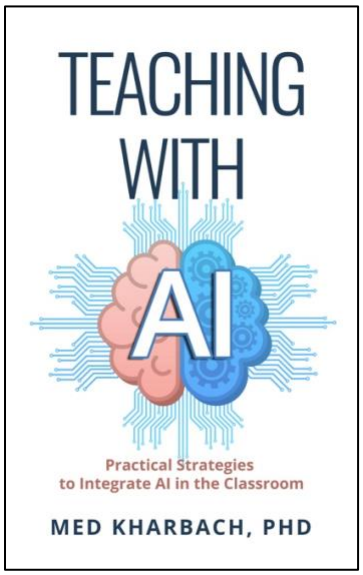
License details: creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-sa/4.0/

# Teaching with AI

## Practical Strategies to Integrate AI in The Classroom

In Teaching with AI, I speak directly to you as a teacher working through real classroom questions about AI. The book helps you build strong AI literacy so you understand how these systems work, where they help, and where caution is needed. I share concrete classroom strategies, examples drawn from practice, and ways to align AI use with sound pedagogy and professional judgment. My goal is to support you in using AI thoughtfully as part of your teaching, in ways that deepen learning and keep human expertise at the center.

**Grab your copy here.**



# How to Become an AI-Literate Teacher: A Step-by-Step Guide

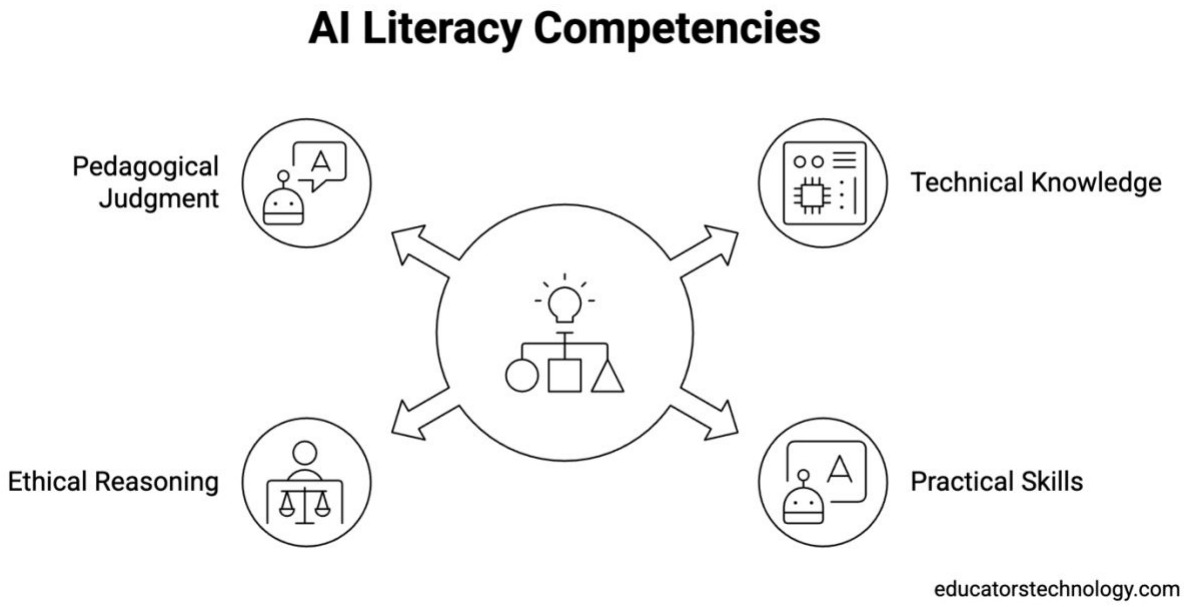
After fifteen years of reviewing edtech tools on Educators Technology, I thought I had a good sense of what teacher professional development in this space looks like. But the speed of change around AI has caught even experienced educators off guard. Most teacher preparation programs still have no formal AI literacy component, and the majority of practicing teachers report having received zero structured training on how to use AI tools in their classrooms.

This guide is my attempt to synthesize the best of what is out there into a clear, practical progression. It draws on the major global frameworks, the advice teachers are sharing with each other in real communities, and what the research says about building genuine AI fluency. If you are a teacher who has been meaning to get serious about AI but keeps putting it off because the whole thing feels overwhelming, this is written for you.

## What AI Literacy for Teachers Actually Involves

AI literacy goes well beyond knowing which AI tool to use or how to write better prompts, although both of these are important. AI literacy involves four connected areas of understanding: technical knowledge (how AI models work at a basic level, what training data is, why AI sometimes generates false information), practical skills (using tools effectively for instruction, planning, and assessment), ethical reasoning (recognizing bias, protecting student privacy, thinking about fairness), and pedagogical judgment (deciding when AI adds genuine value to learning and when it gets in the way).

Every major framework published in the last two years, from UNESCO to the OECD to Stanford's Teaching Commons, agrees on one point: AI literacy is a progression, not a destination. You build it in stages. The UNESCO AI Competency Framework for Teachers (2024) lays this out across three levels: Acquire (foundational understanding), Deepen (designing AI-integrated pedagogical strategies), and Create (innovating with AI systems in education). You do not need to reach the third level to be effective. But you do need to start.




## Step 1: Build Foundational Knowledge About How AI Works

Foundational knowledge in the context of developing AI literacy does not mean developing advanced technical skills and insights and it definitely does not require a computer science degree. Foundational knowledge refers to that basic knowledge that allows you to tell the difference between genuinely useful AI output and confident-sounding nonsense. And to be able to do so, you need to learn what large language models are, how they generate text by predicting the next word based on patterns in their training data, and how and why they can produce fluent writing that is completely wrong.

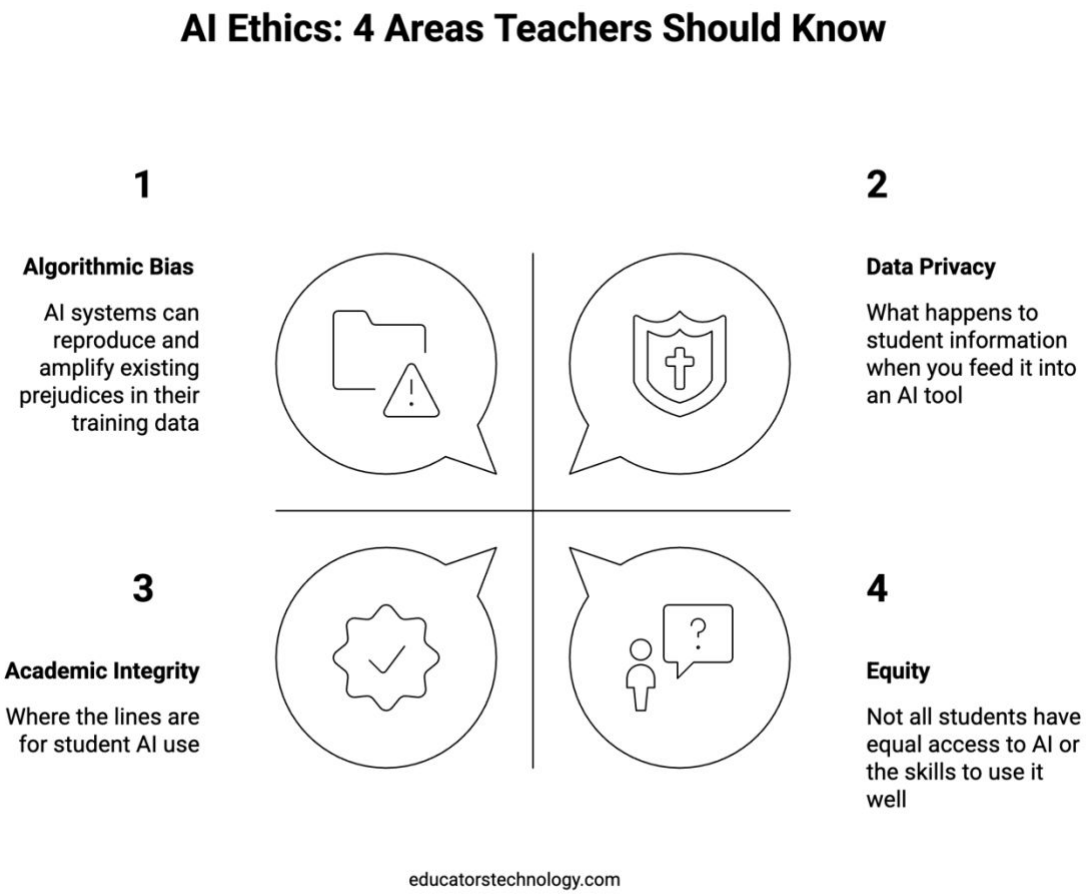
The OECD's new AILit Framework (2025) organizes this foundational knowledge around a practical question: can you recognize when AI is present in the tools you already use? Many educational platforms, from learning management systems to adaptive math programs, already use AI in ways that are not always obvious. Knowing how to spot it and evaluate what it is doing is the first step.

Building this foundation works best when you do not go at it alone. Conversations with fellow teachers, whether in staff rooms, at conferences, or across social media communities where educators share what they are testing and learning in real time, will sharpen your understanding faster than any solo reading session. Even more valuable is investing in structured professional development. I have curated several free AI courses designed specifically for educators, and you can check out my full guide for the complete list.

## Step 2: Understand the Ethical Terrain

Understanding AI ethics goes hand in hand with building your foundational AI knowledge. I know ethical terrain is vast and complex but here four main areas that you should pay attention as a teacher: algorithmic bias (AI systems can reproduce and amplify existing prejudices in their training data), data privacy (what happens to student information when you feed it into an AI tool), academic integrity (where the lines are for student AI use), and equity (not all students have equal access to AI or the skills to use it well).

Common Sense Education offers a practical reminder that is easy to miss: information that does not look like personally identifiable information can still create privacy problems. A student's pet name, birthday, or favorite restaurant might seem harmless, but in combination with other data points, these details can be identifying. The rule is simple: never type student names, grades, IEP information, or any personal details into AI tools.




**Recommended Resources for Learning About AI Ethics in Education:**

Common Sense Education: AI Literacy Lessons for Grades 6-12 - Grab-and-go lessons that cover bias, privacy, deepfakes, and the social impact of AI, designed for classroom use but equally useful for teachers building their own understanding.

Teaching AI Ethics: A Guide for Educators - Leon Furze's free, open-access series (now a full eBook) covering nine topics from algorithmic bias to data privacy to power, with case studies and inquiry questions mapped to curriculum areas across multiple subjects.

European Commission: Ethical Guidelines for Educators on Using AI - Practical support for primary and secondary teachers navigating ethical decisions around AI in the classroom, including guidance on data protection and avoiding algorithmic bias.

UNESCO: AI Competency Framework for Teachers - The first global framework for AI competencies in teaching, with a dedicated ethics strand covering privacy, data protection, and bias. Organized across three progression levels (Acquire, Deepen, Create), so you can start wherever you are.

ISTE: Hands-On AI Projects for the Classroom - Free downloadable guides (available in English, Spanish, and Arabic) with a dedicated AI ethics guide alongside subject-specific resources for elementary, secondary, and computer science educators.

## Step 3: Get Hands-On with a Few Reliable AI Tools

The biggest mistake new users make is trying to learn too many tools at once. The consistent advice from experienced AI-using educators is to pick three or four reliable platforms and learn them well.

A solid starting kit might include a general-purpose AI assistant like ChatGPT or Claude for lesson planning, content drafting, and brainstorming. Add a teacher-specific platform like Eduaide, Edcafe, or MagicSchool.ai, which offers dozens of built-in templates for common tasks like rubric creation, differentiation, and assessment writing. Then add one subject-specific tool that fits your discipline.

Focus first on the tasks that drain your energy: writing differentiated materials, building assessments, drafting parent communications, creating substitute plans. These are the quick wins. Once you see how much time AI can save on routine work, you will have the motivation to go deeper.

## Step 4: Learn to Prompt Effectively

The difference between mediocre AI output and genuinely useful results almost always comes down to how you ask. Prompt engineering, the skill of crafting specific, well-structured requests, is rapidly becoming one of the most important literacy skills for educators.

Good prompting means telling the AI what format you want (a bulleted list, a paragraph, a table), who the audience is (8th graders, parents, administrators), what tone to use (formal, conversational, encouraging), and what context matters (subject area, learning objectives, student needs). When the first result is not what you need, revise the prompt and try again. This is an iterative skill, and it improves with practice.

One tip that experienced teachers share frequently: ask the AI to respond as a specific persona. "Act as a 5th-grade science teacher explaining photosynthesis to students who struggle with reading" produces very different output than a generic request for a photosynthesis explanation.

## Step 5: Develop Critical Evaluation Habits

AI is a powerful drafting partner and a terrible fact-checker. Every output needs to be reviewed for accuracy, bias, and appropriateness before it goes anywhere near your students. This is not optional. It is the single most important habit to build early.

Train yourself to ask three questions about every AI-generated output: Is this factually accurate? Whose perspective might be missing or underrepresented? Would this content be fair and appropriate for all students in my classroom? These questions take seconds, and they will prevent most of the problems that give AI in education a bad name.

## Step 6: Move from Personal Productivity to Classroom Integration

Once you are comfortable using AI for your own planning and preparation, the next step is thinking about how it fits into your teaching. This is where the OECD framework's "Create with AI" domain comes alive: using AI as a collaborative partner for problem-solving and creativity in actual instruction.

Practical examples from educators who have done this successfully include: having students fact-check or critique AI-generated text as a critical thinking exercise, using AI to create data sets for math or science analysis, asking students to prompt-engineer responses from historical figures or literary characters, and using AI-generated first drafts as starting points for student revision and improvement.

The key principle across every framework and teacher community I reviewed: AI literacy should be woven into existing subjects and curriculum, not siloed into a standalone "AI class." A history teacher who has students evaluate AI-generated historical analysis is teaching AI literacy. A science teacher who has students compare AI explanations to textbook explanations is teaching AI literacy. The content area is the context.

## Step 7: Set Clear Guidelines and Model AI Use for Students

Every teacher needs a clear, stated position on AI use in their classroom. Students need to know what is expected, what is allowed, and why the boundaries exist where they do. Without this clarity, confusion fills the gap, and confusion breeds anxiety.

Three questions from the UNESCO and Jisc guidance that every teacher should be able to answer:

- What is my position on student AI use, and have I communicated it clearly?
- How am I integrating AI literacy into my subject area?

- How am I using AI to reduce my own workload through planning, grading, or administrative tasks?

One of the most practical steps you can take is creating an AI agreement for your class. I prefer calling it an agreement rather than a policy because the process matters as much as the document. Bring your students into the conversation. Let them help shape the terms. When students participate in setting the boundaries, they understand the reasoning behind them and are far more likely to respect them.

A strong AI agreement typically covers: which AI tools are approved for class use and which are off-limits, when students can use AI assistance and when the work needs to be fully their own, how students should cite or disclose AI use in their submissions, what information is never appropriate to share with AI tools (personal data, other students' work, confidential school information), and what the consequences look like when the agreement is not followed. Draft it together, revisit it at least once a semester as tools and expectations shift, and treat it as a living document that is continuously updated.

For samples of classroom AI use agreement templates, check out this guide.

# Our Classroom AI Agreement

**A shared guide for how we use AI tools in our class**



## Why We Use AI

We use AI to support our learning. It helps us shape ideas, get organized, and move forward when we feel stuck. It doesn't replace our thinking; it helps us build on it.



## Tools We Use

ChatGPT, Claude, Canva, MagicSchool, SlidesAI, and other school-approved tools. The list can change across the year as new tools appear or old ones fade out.



## What's Okay & What's Not

We follow a simple color guide:

| Red | Yellow | Green |
|---|---|---|
| Full AI-written work | Light help: Grammar, quick summaries, etc. | Brainstorming, visuals |



## Tell Me How You Used AI

For any assignment where AI helped you, include:

- Tool used
- Input given
- What you kept/changed
- How you checked accuracy



## Privacy & Safety

Keep personal details out of public tools. Don't share names, IDs, or private information. We stick to platforms our school approves.



## Equity & Access

Not every student has the same tools at home. We make sure there are alternatives so no one is left out or marked down.



## If Something Goes Wrong

We talk first. You can fix the work or try again. School rules apply only if the same issue keeps happening.



## Review & Revisit

We'll look at this agreement again after our first major project and later in the term. We can adjust it anytime if new tools show up or if we want it to work better.

## Step 8: Commit to Ongoing Learning

AI tools change fast. Features shift, new platforms appear, old ones disappear, and capabilities that seemed impossible six months ago become standard. A one-time training session is not going to cut it.

Build a small, sustainable learning routine. Follow two or three trusted sources (newsletters, blogs, LinkedIn voices) who cover AI in education. Join a professional learning community, even an informal one. Take advantage of free structured training when it becomes available: Google and ISTE launched free AI literacy modules for all U.S. educators in 2026, Jisc offers a curriculum for UK teaching staff, and the UNESCO framework is free to download and use as a self-guided assessment.

Set a monthly reminder to try one new thing, whether that is a new tool feature, a new prompting strategy, or a new way of integrating AI into a lesson. Small, consistent steps add up to genuine fluency.

My Free AI Courses guide features a wide variety of  platforms where you can access AI courses to enhance your PD efforts!

### Tips for Building Your AI Literacy

**1. Start with one tool and one task:** Pick something that drains your energy, like writing report card comments or building a rubric, and use ChatGPT or Claude to draft it. You will see the value immediately and build momentum from there.

**2. Learn to prompt well before learning more tools:** The quality of AI output depends almost entirely on how you frame your request. Specify the audience, format, tone, and context. Iterate when the first result falls flat. This single skill will improve every AI interaction you have.

**3. Never trust AI output without checking it:** AI tools fabricate information confidently. Every output needs a human review for accuracy, bias, and fit. Teach yourself this habit early, because you will need to teach your students the same thing.

**4. Protect student data at all times:** Do not type student names, grades, IEP details, or any identifying information into any AI tool. Even details that seem harmless (a pet's name, a birthdate) can create privacy risks when combined.

**5. Join a professional learning community:** Find a group of educators who are experimenting with AI, whether on LinkedIn, a Substack newsletter, a district cohort, or an informal teacher group. You will learn faster from peers than from any webinar.

**6. Use free structured training when available:** Google and ISTE launched free AI literacy modules for all U.S. educators in 2026, and Jisc offers a curriculum for UK-based teaching staff. UNESCO's AI Competency Framework for Teachers is free to download and use as a self-assessment guide.

**7. Move from personal productivity to classroom integration gradually:** Once you are comfortable using AI for your own planning, start thinking about how it fits into student learning. Have students critique AI outputs, debate AI ethics, or use AI-generated materials as discussion starters.

**8. Talk openly about AI with your students:** Show them when you use AI and when you choose not to. Explain why some tasks benefit from AI assistance and others

need independent thinking. This kind of modeling is the most powerful AI literacy lesson you can give.

**9. Revisit your knowledge regularly:** AI tools change fast. A feature that worked one way six months ago may behave differently now. Set a recurring reminder to explore one new development per month, even if it is just reading a single article or trying one new feature.

**10. Do not aim for perfection:** You do not need to master everything at once. Every framework available right now, from UNESCO to OECD to Stanford, treats AI literacy as a progression. Start where you are and build from there.

## Final Thoughts

AI literacy is not something you either have or you do not. It is a set of skills that grows with use, reflection, and hands-on experimentation. Every framework out there, from UNESCO to the OECD to Stanford to Jisc, treats it as a progression. That means wherever you are right now is a valid starting point.

I put this guide together because I know how overwhelming it can feel to look at the AI conversation from the outside and wonder where to begin. You begin with one tool, one task, and one lesson. Then you build from there. Wishing you all the best in your AI integration journey!

# About the Author

Med Kharbach, PhD, is an educator, researcher, and the editor of Educators Technology (educatorstechnology.com). A former K-12 teacher with over a decade of classroom experience, Med currently serves as part-time faculty at Mount Saint Vincent University. He is the author of Teaching with AI: Practical Strategies to Integrate AI in The Classroom, and co-author of The AI Turn in Academic Research with Dr. Jonathan Woodworth. His work focuses on the intersection of technology, pedagogy, and practical classroom applications. You can read more about Med and his research on his professional website www.medkharbach.com.

## References


UNESCO AI Competency Framework for Teachers (2024)

OECD/European Commission AILit Framework (2025)

Stanford Teaching Commons: Understanding AI Literacy

Jisc AI Literacy Curriculum for Teaching Staff (2025)

TeachAI: AI Literacy Resources

Google/ISTE Free AI Training for Educators (2026)

Common Sense Education: Practical Tips for Teachers to Use AI

World Economic Forum: Why AI Literacy Is Now a Core Competency (2025)

Edutopia: Equity and Bias in AI

MiddleWeb: AI Prompt Engineering as a Literacy Skill